
BETWEEN THE LINES

ISSUE NO. 02 · JULY 2026 · KELLY ANDERSON GROUP / IMPACT SOLUTIONS

OPENING

"There's a bunch of trucking companies right now that are trying to find drivers, legally compliant drivers, because of the ones that have been pushed out. There are cabs that are sitting empty." That quote from AscendTMS CEO Tim Higham captures the month in one breath [FreightWaves]. Driver pay just posted its biggest two-month jump on record, spot rates topped contract for the first time since 2022, and LTL carriers are absorbing overflow from a truckload market that's finally tight again [FreightWaves][DC Velocity]. Inside: what's real, what's fragile, and what to watch.

THE BIG STORY

The rate rebound is real. The reason isn't what most people think.

The freight market has turned. Capacity, not demand, is doing the heavy lifting.

The Truck Driver Pay Index jumped from 150.83 in April to 170.04 in June, a 13.5% surge in two months and easily the largest short-window gain since the index began in 2020 [FreightWaves]. Superior Trucking Payroll's Mike Ritzema said he's never seen driver wages move like this. It aligns with spot rates that have finally punched through contract levels for the first time in more than three years, and with flatbed hitting an all-time high in June [DC Velocity].

13.5%

DRIVER PAY SURGE,
APRIL TO JUNE

20.4

RECORD FTR
TRUCKING

7.1%

SAIA'S JULY LTL RATE
INCREASE

\$62M

FEDERAL TRUCK
PARKING GRANTS

But peel back the numbers and the story isn't a demand boom. DAT analyst Dean Croke put it bluntly: "If demand were driving this, volumes would be climbing too, and they're not" [DC Velocity]. FTR's Trucking Conditions Index hit a record 20.4 in May, yet FTR's Avery Vise warned the rebound is "principally a function of already-tight capacity followed by a series of disruptions," not broad-based freight growth [DC Velocity].

"If demand were driving this, volumes would be climbing too, and they're not."

Dean Croke, DAT Freight & Analytics

What's tightening capacity? Enforcement. The Trump administration's crackdown on non-domiciled CDLs, tougher English-language proficiency checks, and the shuttering of some driving schools have quietly pulled thousands of drivers off the road [DC Velocity]. Estes Express President Webb Estes called it a "double whammy": fewer drivers now, and fewer schools to replenish the ranks later [Transport Topics]. Meanwhile bankruptcies keep grinding through the small-carrier tier, with nine more transportation and logistics firms filing over two weeks in July [FreightWaves].

LTL is riding the wave. ArcBest saw weight-per-shipment jump 5% between April and May; Saia pushed through a 7.1% general rate increase in July; and FedEx Freight, newly spun off as a standalone public company, is chasing food and beverage, healthcare, and SMB freight it has historically underserved [Transport Topics]. Amazon formally entered LTL in June, though with a notably asset-light footprint of under 100 cross-docks versus roughly 300 for the top five incumbents [Transport Topics].

The takeaway for operators: pricing power is real, but it's built on a thin foundation. If enforcement eases or freight volumes stall, the capacity story gets a lot less compelling. For now, though, carriers with drivers in seats are finally getting paid what the work is worth.

QUICK TAKES

What else moved the market this month.

The Supreme Court just changed broker liability, and the AI question got harder

After the unanimous Montgomery ruling on broker negligent selection, C.H. Robinson's very public AI push is drawing pointed questions about whether that same investment is flowing into carrier vetting [FreightWaves]. Transportation attorney Cassandra Gaines framed it sharply: "AI agents without context aren't worthwhile," and brokers can't credibly automate pricing and tracking while leaving safety vetting on autopilot. Expect plaintiff attorneys to make exactly that argument.

OCEAN

Hormuz toll plan sends shockwaves through global shipping

President Trump announced the U.S. will reinstate its Iranian blockade and charge 20% of cargo value for Strait of Hormuz transits, a fee that could add roughly \$10,000 per container on a typical box valued at \$50,000 [The Loadstar]. Brent crude jumped past \$86, oil prices climbed for a second straight day, and DP World is fast-tracking a new UAE terminal at Fujairah specifically to bypass the strait [Transport Topics][FreightWaves]. Fuel volatility is back on the table.

INFRASTRUCTURE

\$62 million in federal grants target truck parking

USDOT's latest BUILD grant round included \$62 million for truck parking projects across Kentucky, Wyoming, Louisiana, Mississippi, and Illinois. Kentucky alone gets \$25 million to add spaces at seven rest areas on four major corridors [FreightWaves]. It's a modest slice of the \$1.73 billion package, but a rare federal acknowledgment of a problem drivers have been raising for years.

REGULATION

EPA moves to kill DEF derates

EPA proposed eliminating engine derates triggered by diesel exhaust fluid system issues, replacing them with dashboard alerts [Transport Topics]. ATA's Patrick Kelly welcomed the flexibility, noting derates can strand trucks, though truck-stop and fuel-marketer groups pushed back, warning it could undermine one of trucking's clearest emissions success stories. Cummins, Paccar, and Daimler are already rolling out related software updates covering millions of engines.

LABOR

Illinois contractor case goes class action

A federal judge granted class-action status to a Fair Labor Standards Act suit against Illinois carrier Risinger Brothers Transfer, potentially sweeping in lease-purchase, owner-operator, team, and brokerage drivers alleging they were misclassified as contractors [FreightWaves]. The core claim, that deductions drove effective pay below minimum wage, is familiar territory. What's new is the class certification, which raises the stakes for any carrier running a lease-purchase model.

INFRASTRUCTURE

Gordie Howe Bridge finally opens July 27

After a six-week delay over toll revenue-sharing, the U.S. and Canada agreed to open the new Detroit-Windsor crossing on July 27 [Supply Chain Dive]. The Canadian Trucking Alliance expects immediate efficiency gains on the busiest commercial trade corridor between the two countries, with modern customs facilities and direct freeway-to-freeway connections reducing congestion at the aging Ambassador Bridge.

WHAT TO WATCH

Stories worth tracking into next month.

DRIVERS

Will driver pay keep climbing into fall?

Superior's Ritzema notes a four-to-six-month lag between spot rate moves and driver wages, meaning the recent rate surge should continue pushing pay higher into Q3 and Q4 [FreightWaves]. If enforcement-driven capacity tightness holds, carriers should plan compensation reviews and recruiting budgets around materially higher wage baselines than they modeled six months ago.

SUPPLY CHAIN

Peak season inventory pull-forward is already underway

The Logistics Managers Index hit 71.1 in June, its second-highest reading since March 2022, driven by retailers stockpiling ahead of potential tariff escalations later in July [DC Velocity]. GEP's June data shows manufacturer safety-stock building at levels last seen in early 2023.

Expect compressed peak-season timing and heavier August through September volumes for final-mile fleets.

LTL

FedEx Freight and Amazon reshape the LTL competitive map

A newly independent FedEx Freight is publicly targeting SMB, food and beverage, healthcare, and data center freight, segments where CEO John Smith admits penetration is minimal or "basically zero" [Transport Topics]. Amazon's asset-light LTL entrance adds a second wild card. Watch for pricing pressure in specific verticals even as headline GRIs continue climbing.

THE BOTTOM LINE

This month's freight strength is real but structurally fragile, built on enforcement-driven capacity cuts rather than shipper demand. For carriers and final-mile operators, the window is open to lock in rate discipline, invest in driver pay, and tighten the safety and vetting practices the courts are now scrutinizing. The operators who use this stretch to build durable capability, not just ride the cycle, will be the ones still standing when the next turn comes.

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SOURCES ▴

Compiled 2026-07-14 from 5 publications over the past 30 days.

DC Velocity

- 2026-07-13 Business stockpile inventory amid uncertainty about US-Iran ceasefire
- 2026-07-13 Georgia Ports names Price to succeed Lynch as CEO
- 2026-07-13 Port of LA offers \$300k incentive to buy electric drayage trucks
- 2026-07-13 Fuelish thinking
- 2026-07-13 Smart robotics save the day
- 2026-07-09 Element Logic and Lululemon open 1 million square foot Ontario warehouse
- 2026-07-09 Peak Technologies names Heel as new CEO
- 2026-07-09 DAT: Truckload rate recovery is based on tight capacity, not broad demand
- 2026-07-09 Logistics activity expanded in June
- 2026-07-08 FTR: Trucking sector recovery to hit a ceiling without better freight growth

FreightWaves

- 2026-07-14 Big Rig Crash Closes Eastbound I-80 Near Donner Pass
- 2026-07-14 Freight Distress Report: Carrier, logistics closures erase over 245 jobs
- 2026-07-14 Don't Get in Trouble Again, C.H. Robinson: AI Everywhere Except Carrier Vetting Is a Problem
- 2026-07-14 Index of driver pay, product of two companies, is surging
- 2026-07-14 Project44 forms two new businesses, launches AI-native LSP44
- 2026-07-14 Jaxport adds new Asia-LatAm-Med container service
- 2026-07-14 Norfolk Southern conductor struck, killed by train in Indiana
- 2026-07-14 DP World plans UAE port, container terminal to bypass Strait of Hormuz: Report
- 2026-07-13 Illinois employee driver v. contractor lawsuit now a class action fight
- 2026-07-13 Federal grants set \$62M for truck parking in five states

Supply Chain Dive

- 2026-07-14 Strauss, DHL Supply Chain ink end-to-end logistics deal
- 2026-07-14 Port of Savannah-linked corridor to streamline flow of goods
- 2026-07-14 Should the Postal Service reassess its UPS air contract?
- 2026-07-14 PepsiCo improves sustainable sourcing, delays emissions reporting
- 2026-07-14 Mars to close Nature's Bakery plant, lay off 345 workers
- 2026-07-13 General Mills plans supply chain revamp as part of \$3B cost-cutting effort
- 2026-07-13 Gordie Howe bridge set to open July 27 after weekslong delay

- 2026-07-13 Amazon preps robotics-equipped sorting warehouse in Texas
- 2026-07-13 Amazon announces 2026 holiday fulfillment fees, advises early shipping
- 2026-07-13 How restaurants can combat ingredient inconsistencies

The Loadstar

- 2026-07-14 Tariff refund bandwagon rolls on, but SMEs struggling
- 2026-07-14 Loadstar Leader: Trump Hormuz toll plan catastrophic for box shipping
- 2026-07-14 Cargo chaos in North Asian ports as Typhoon Bavi blows in
- 2026-07-14 Why China's port giants are sitting out the big M&A cycle
- 2026-07-14 Container rate rally has more legs than bears assume
- 2026-07-14 Ex-Schenker/DSV leader rumoured to join DHL Group
- 2026-07-14 Transpacific the top earner as a strong Q2 boosts OOCL revenue
- 2026-07-14 FedEx-CMA CGM deal hints at new battle for air cargo capacity
- 2026-07-14 AI hardware props up air freight, spare a thought for the downside
- 2026-07-14 Air Canada and Avianca set course for network alignment

Transport Topics

- 2026-07-14 Uber is in advanced talks to acquire Delivery Hero
- 2026-07-14 LTL carriers eye further growth due to truckload constraints
- 2026-07-14 Falling gas prices cut inflation last month
- 2026-07-14 Oil prices soar over \$85 as fighting flares in Middle East
- 2026-07-14 Here's why it's so difficult for U.S. to fully reopen Hormuz
- 2026-07-13 EPA proposes end to DEF derates to mixed reception
- 2026-07-13 U.S. budget deficit widens as tariff refunds surge
- 2026-07-13 Trump's Jones Act waiver sparks long-term policy fight
- 2026-07-13 Iran shipped 57M barrels of crude oil between U.S. blockades
- 2026-07-13 Trump says U.S. will blockade Iran in Strait of Hormuz